

Nirvan Sutra

Chapter 3

The Witness — In Depth

Living as the Witness in ordinary life

Aadisatv

First Section — The Witness in the Middle of Life

From the Previous Chapters

In the first chapter, the seeker turned inward. The body was seen, the mind was seen, the experiencer was seen, and then the quiet knowing presence called the Witness was recognized. In the second chapter, the seeker turned outward and began to understand the world, name, form, and Maya. Now the question becomes practical: how can this understanding remain alive in every turn of life?

When reading quietly, the Witness may feel easy to understand. But life continues. Someone speaks. A relationship hurts. Work fails. Desire arises. Fear comes. Success and failure appear. At such moments the seeker often returns to the experiencer and says, “This happened to me,” “I am hurt,” “I failed.”

So now we will not keep witnessing as an idea. We will see it in the middle of moving life.

The Common Misunderstanding: Witnessing Only Happens in Meditation

Many seekers believe witnessing happens only when they sit in a quiet room, close the eyes, and meditate. Meditation is useful, but this understanding is incomplete.

Witnessing is available while walking, speaking, listening, eating, working, feeling anger, or enjoying happiness. The Witness is not a special state. It is the quiet knowing presence that knows every state. Peace is known. Restlessness is known. Stillness is known. Movement is known.

To limit witnessing to meditation is like saying light exists only in the prayer room and not in the rest of the house. If a lamp is lit, it reveals wherever it reaches. In the same way, knowing is present in every experience.

Witnessing and Concentration Are Different

Witnessing is not tense alertness. It is not an inner guard watching every thought with pressure. It is simple knowing.

The eye does not struggle to see. When the eye is open and light is present, seeing happens naturally. In the same way, the Witness knows naturally. A thought appears - it is known. A feeling rises - it is known. The body is tired - it is known. A sound comes - it is known.

A fan may be running in the room, but until attention goes there, the sound remains in the background. When someone says, "Listen to the fan," you notice it was already present. You did not create it; attention returned. Witnessing is like that.

Where Witnessing Is Forgotten Most

There are three areas where old identity becomes active quickly.

First: relationships. Words from someone close hurt more deeply because expectations, memories, and personal identity are involved.

Second: work and results. Success says, “I am successful.” Failure says, “I am a failure.” The experiencer attaches identity to outcomes.

Third: deep emotions. Fear, grief, anger, jealousy, and loneliness can become so strong that the seeker forgets the emotion is being known.

This chapter looks at these three areas, because witnessing becomes stable not only in quietness, but in the very places where it is forgotten.

Witnessing Is a Return

If witnessing is treated only as a practice, the mind may turn it into another achievement. The experiencer may ask, “How well did I witness today?”

So here we call witnessing a return. Return means coming back to what is already present. The Witness is not newly created. Knowing is already present.

Attention becomes entangled in experience, and then it returns.

When lost in thought, return. When carried by emotion, return. When praise expands you or criticism shrinks you, return. Forgetting is old habit. Returning is sadhana.

Practice for Today

Choose one simple activity - drinking tea, eating, walking, climbing stairs, washing your hands, or speaking to someone briefly. During it, pause inwardly three times and notice:

“This action is happening.”

“The body is doing it.”

“Something is knowing it.”

Do not try to catch the knowing. Simply recognize that experience is happening and is being known.

Second Section — Witnessing in Relationships

Relationships Are the Living Test

In relationships, the mind reacts quickly. Someone close says something, and a wave rises within - hurt, anger, fear, insult, expectation, complaint. The matter may look small from outside, yet it feels deep within.

Relationships are both the greatest test and the greatest possibility. They are a test because the experiencer becomes active quickly. They are a possibility because when witnessing enters relationships, old knots begin to loosen.

Why Hurt Goes Deep in Relationships

A stranger's harsh word may irritate you and pass. But the same words from someone close can wound deeply. In close relationships, there are not just words. There are expectations, old memories, the need for

recognition, the desire for love, and the wish for respect.

If a loved one says, “You never understand,” an entire story may rise: “I do so much, yet I am not seen,” “I am not valued.” One sentence came from outside, but the experiencer lifted a story inside.

The Witness does not say there is no hurt. It simply knows: “The experience of hurt is arising.” This knowing reduces blind reaction.

Listening as the Witness

Usually we do not truly listen. Someone speaks and we already prepare an answer inside. The sentence has not even ended, and reaction is ready.

Listening with witnessing means hearing the other person and also seeing what rises within. Words are coming from outside. Defense is rising inside. Both are being seen.

This does not mean remaining silent and tolerating everything. It means responding after seeing, setting

boundaries without blind anger, and speaking truth without speaking only from hurt.

The Art of Pausing

When harsh words are heard, the body tightens, the breath changes, and the mind prepares defense. A small pause can change the direction of the conversation.

Without witnessing:

Person A: “You never listen to me.”

Person B: “Really? When do you listen to me?”

Person A: “See, you started arguing again.”

Person B: “Because you always blame me.”

Both are speaking from the experiencer. The real issue is lost.

With a little witnessing:

Person A: “You never listen to me.”

Person B feels defense rising and takes one breath.

Person B: “I notice a defensive reaction in me, but I want to understand. What made you feel I was not

listening?”

Person A: “When I was sharing my problem, you were looking at your phone.”

Person B: “I can see that. Perhaps I was not fully present.”

No one was defeated. A pause came. Reaction was seen. Response came with clarity.

Naming the Hurt of the Experiencer

When someone does not listen, see: “The ‘I’ that wants importance is arising.” When criticism comes: “The ‘I’ that wants to be right is arising.” When expectation is not met: “The ‘I’ that wants love in its own way is arising.”

This does not suppress hurt. It names it. Naming opens space. Space is not coldness; it is clarity.

Love and Clinging

We often mistake clinging for love. “Be the way I want, because I love you.” This sounds like love but may contain fear and control.

Love has tenderness. Clinging has fear. Love sees the other. Clinging wants to shape the other.

Witnessing does not make relationships cold. It purifies love. It reveals, “I love this person, but fear is mixed with my love.” Seeing this makes love more truthful.

Practice for Today

Observe one conversation today. During or after it, ask:

Did I truly listen, or was I preparing my reply?

Which sentence activated the experiencer?

What desire or wound arose - respect, being understood, being right, or love?

If you became entangled, that is also fine. Seeing afterward is also sadhana.

Third Section — Witnessing in Work, Effort, and Results

Seeing the Field of Work

In work, the experiencer becomes strong through results. When work goes well, it says, “I am successful.” When work fails, it says, “I am a failure.” Praise says, “I am capable.” Criticism says, “I am not capable.”

Work is part of life. Effort is necessary. Responsibility is not against sadhana. But turning work and results into final identity creates suffering.

Identity with Results

Results come: exams, projects, business, praise, rejection. From outside these are events. The experiencer turns them into identity.

A student receives marks lower than expected. The event is simple: the marks were low. But the

experiencer says, “I am a failure,” “I am less than others,” “Nothing will happen through me.”

A person starts a business and it does not work. The event is that the business result was unfavorable. But the experiencer says, “I was wrong,” “I am not capable,” “I ruined everything.”

The pain is not only from the result; it is from tying the result to “me.” Witnessing sees: result has come, disappointment is arising, the body feels heavy, the future is feared, and all this is being known.

Effort and Result Are Different

Witnessing does not say, “Do not work hard.” It does not promote laziness. It says: work sincerely, prepare, learn, improve, fulfill responsibility, but do not make the result the proof of your final identity.

Effort is in your hands. Honesty is in your hands. Preparation and learning are in your hands. But results arise from many factors - circumstance, timing, other people, the market, and unseen causes.

A farmer plants seeds and works carefully, but rain and weather are not fully in his hands. This does not make him careless. It makes him do his part with clarity.

A person with witnessing is not less hardworking. He is clearer. He works from clarity, not from fear of identity collapsing.

Example: A Project Fails

A person works hard on an office project. He plans, coordinates, and prepares. On the presentation day, the client is not satisfied and the project is paused.

Without witnessing, the experiencer says, “I am not capable,” “People will think less of me.” The mind repeats the scene.

With witnessing, he sees: the project failed, disappointment arose, criticism hurt, the experiencer is worried about image. Then clarity becomes possible: “A mistake happened. I must learn and improve. But this result is not the verdict on my whole being.”

Now learning can happen: where was preparation weak, where was communication unclear, what can be improved next time?

The Trap of Comparison

Work often brings comparison: “They earned more,” “They are ahead,” “At my age they achieved more,” “I am behind.”

Witnessing does not forcibly stop comparison thoughts. It sees them: “A comparison thought is arising,” “The mind is measuring my value through another person,” “The experiencer is afraid of being left behind.”

Comparison as a thought is not bondage. Making identity out of it is bondage. Inspiration brings learning energy. Comparison brings the pain of insufficiency.

Rising After Failure

Failure will come. When it comes, give space to the pain. If disappointment is present, see it. If the body is

heavy, know it. If fear rises, do not suppress it. Witnessing is not a trick to erase pain; it is clarity that knows pain.

If a small business closes, the experiencer may say, “I am a failure.” Witnessing can see: “The business did not work. Pain and shame are arising. But this is not my whole identity. It is an experience and a lesson.”

When identity does not break, learning becomes possible.

Awareness in Success

Witnessing is needed in success too. Success brings joy; do not suppress it. Honor your effort and be grateful. But success can also strengthen ego: “I am great,” “This happened only because of me.”

Witnessing shows that success too is an experience. Joy is arising. Praise is being received. A wave of ego may be rising. This is being known.

Practice for Today

Remember a recent success or failure and ask:

What was the event?

What identity did the experiencer create from it?

If it is seen as an experience and a lesson, what is the next clear step?

Just see honestly. This is witnessing in work and results.

Fourth Section — Witnessing Deep Emotions and Closing the Chapter

Entering Deep Emotions

Relationships bring hurt. Work brings identity with results. But when fear, grief, anger, jealousy, loneliness, or insecurity rise intensely, the seeker may be swept away. At that time it is difficult to remember that emotion is being known.

Witnessing is not denying emotion, running away from it, or covering it with spiritual words. It means knowing the emotion honestly without turning it into your final identity.

Emotion Appears, But You Are Not Only Emotion

Deep emotion is felt in the body. Fear may tighten the chest. Anger may heat the face. Grief may make the body heavy. Loneliness may feel like emptiness.

So emotion feels real, and at the level of experience it is real. Do not call it false. Sadhana does not mean removing emotions; it means being honest with them.

But see: is the emotion permanent? Fear comes and changes. Anger rises and settles. Grief becomes lighter. Emotions arise, affect body and mind, and change. Witnessing sees: “Fear is arising,” “Grief is being experienced,” “Anger is here.” This is not suppression; it is bringing emotion into light.

Seeing Fear

Fear comes in many forms - fear of the future, failure, loss, loneliness, illness, insult. The experiencer says, “I am unsafe,” and the mind creates a future story.

The first step is naming: “Fear is arising,” “The mind is imagining the future,” “The body is tight.” This may not erase fear, but now you are not completely lost in it.

Then ask: what is actually happening now? Is danger present, or is the mind painting the future? What practical action is needed?

Seeing Grief

Grief often becomes identity: “I am sad,” “Why did this happen to me?” Grief must be respected. Do not make it small in the name of spirituality. If the heart is hurt, it needs time.

Witnessing does not remove grief by saying, “This is all Maya.” It says, “Grief is here, and it is being known.” Give it space. Feel the heaviness. Let tears be known. See gently: “Grief is being experienced. The heart is heavy. This is being known.”

Seeing Anger

Anger wants to speak and react immediately. It has energy. Do not merely call it bad and suppress it. Sometimes anger hides hurt; sometimes it shows a boundary has been crossed.

Witnessing sees anger: “Anger is rising,” “There is heat in the body,” “There is a strong urge to answer.” Anger arising is one thing. Speaking immediately from anger is another. Seeing anger and then speaking with clarity is a third possibility. Witnessing opens that third possibility.

Emotion and Story Are Different

Emotion is direct sensation. Story is what the mind builds around it.

Grief arises, and the story says, “This always happens to me.” Fear arises, and the story says, “Everything will go wrong.” Loneliness arises, and the story says, “No one will ever understand me.”

The emotion may be a passing wave, but story extends it. Witnessing helps the seeker see both: “This is emotion,” and “This is the story built on it.”

Witnessing Is Not Emotionlessness

Some seekers think witnessing means no emotion will ever arise. This is incomplete. Witnessing does not mean becoming emotionless. It means emotions may arise, but complete identity is not formed with them.

The goal is not to kill emotion. The goal is not to forget yourself in the middle of emotion. Giving space to emotion and being bound by emotion are different. Witnessing gives space. The experiencer becomes bound.

The Journey of This Chapter

In this chapter we saw that witnessing is not only in meditation. It is available in every moment. We saw witnessing in relationships - listening, pausing, naming hurt, and separating love from clinging. We saw witnessing in work - working sincerely without

turning results into identity. We saw witnessing in deep emotions - knowing emotion without suppressing it or becoming it.

This is the essence: witnessing is not separate from life. It is the art of remembering in the middle of life.

Toward the Next Chapter

The seeker has now seen three foundations: the search for the Self, the nature of Maya and the world, and the way of bringing witnessing into life. In the next chapter, we will look at the layers of ego - the “I” that identifies with body, mind, roles, success, wounds, thoughts, and stories.

There is no hurry. Let this chapter settle into life. Recognize witnessing in small moments. Return again and again.

Closing: Returning Is the Path

Witnessing is not a distant destination. It is the return to the knowing presence already here in every experience. You do not have to leave life, destroy

emotion, run away from relationships, or become indifferent to work. You only have to learn not to forget yourself.

When grief rises, see. When joy comes, see. When anger rises, see. When success comes, see. When failure comes, see. Seeing is returning. Returning is sadhana.

Practice for This Week

For the next seven days, whenever a sharp emotion arises - fear, grief, anger, jealousy, restlessness, or loneliness - do not immediately try to change it. First notice:

Where is this emotion felt in the body?

What story is the mind building on it?

Am I knowing it as an experience, or making identity from it?

Then gently say:

“This emotion is arising. It is being known. I can see it.”